

MEMORANDUM

TO: MCLE Attendees, Office of the County Counsel, County of Sonoma
FROM: John A. Kelly
DATE: July 16, 2026
RE: Case Study: AI in a Traffic Court Matter — Four Demonstrations at the Smallest Scale

MEMORANDUM

The other written materials for this program show AI applied to a large research problem: a comparative survey of civil local rules across all 58 California counties. This memorandum shows the same tools applied at the opposite end of the scale — a single red light camera citation, the smallest contested matter in the California court system. The matter is my own, so there is no client confidentiality concern in presenting it, and it has concluded: the court entered a not-guilty decision after trial by written declaration on June 30, 2026, with a full refund of bail.

The case study is organized as four demonstrations, and each one uses a specific resource or prompt from this program's written materials. The point is not the ticket. It is that the grounding discipline the program teaches is the same at every scale, and that a matter most attorneys would resolve by writing a check can be defended thoroughly in a few hours of attorney time when each step is grounded in something a machine can check.

I. THE MATTER

A red light camera citation issued in Napa County charged a violation of Vehicle Code section 21453, subdivision (b) — failure to stop before a right turn at a steady red signal — captured by an automated traffic enforcement system, with \$301 in bail. The vehicle was not mine; the citation was first issued to the registered owner, who executed an affidavit of nonliability identifying me as the driver, and the citation was reissued. The strategic question was immediate: pay, appear, or contest by trial by written declaration under Vehicle Code section 40902.

II. DEMONSTRATION ONE: THE ENTIRE VEHICLE CODE, LOCALLY, IN THE HARNESS

The first resource in the program materials is the California codes repository — the complete text of all twenty-nine California codes in machine-readable form, synced nightly from the Legislature's own bulk data:

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https://github.com/johnakelly-yahoo-com/california-codes
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The Vehicle Code from that repository was placed in the working folder, and the model was directed to answer only from it, using the document-grounded prompt from the Curated Prompts

memorandum:

Use only the attached [document, code section, or file] to answer. Quote the exact language you rely on, with its location (section, page, or line). If the attached material does not contain the answer, say "Not found in the provided source." Do not use outside knowledge or training data.

Grounding mattered immediately, for a reason worth pausing on. Senate Bill 720 (Stats. 2025, ch. 782) added Vehicle Code section 21455.9 effective January 1, 2026, creating a new civil penalty framework for automated enforcement with a \$100 cap on first offenses and no DMV points. A model relying on its training data would likely have missed or garbled a statute that new. Working from the current statutory text, the analysis correctly distinguished the two frameworks, confirmed that this citation — with \$301 bail and Superior Court processing — was proceeding under the older court-based framework of section 21455.5, and then extracted every operational requirement that framework imposes on the enforcing agency: the 15-day mailing rule (§ 40518, subd. (a)), signage within 200 feet (§ 21455.5, subd. (a)(1)), right-turn screening guidelines (§ 21455.5, subd. (c)(1)), calibration and inspection (§ 21455.5, subd. (c)(2)), yellow-light timing per the California MUTCD (§ 21455.7), individual law enforcement review of each citation (§ 21455.5, subd. (c)(2)(F)), the pre-contract public hearing (§ 21455.6, subd. (a)), and the ban on per-citation vendor compensation (§ 21455.5, subd. (h)(1)). Every one of those became a challenge ground, and each quoted the statutory language with its location, because the prompt required it.

III. DEMONSTRATION TWO: NAPA COUNTY PROCEDURE FROM THE LOCAL RULES REPOSITORY

The second resource is the county local rules repository — all fifty-eight counties, in a structure suited to AI retrieval:

<https://github.com/johnakelly-yahoo-com/california-local-rules>

The citation was a Napa County matter, and I practice in Sonoma. Rather than working from general assumptions about how a neighboring court processes traffic matters, Napa County's local rules were pulled from the repository and loaded as a source, with the same document-grounded prompt directing the model to answer only from them. That grounding, combined with the court's own posted traffic procedures, framed the practical questions that decide whether a written-declaration defense actually gets filed correctly: how the court takes traffic filings, what had to accompany the request (the bail deposit), and where the papers physically go — which in this case meant the traffic clerk's window at 1111 Third Street in Napa. The filing itself was delivered through an e-filing concierge service with AI-drafted clerk instructions, which is a convenience worth one sentence; the local-rules grounding that made the filing correct is the demonstration.

IV. DEMONSTRATION THREE: AUTHENTICATING THE AUTHORITIES IN WESTLAW

The memoranda in the defense file cited case law as well as statutes — principally *People v. Goldsmith* (2014) 59 Cal.4th 258, the California Supreme Court’s decision on the admissibility of automated enforcement photographs. Citations in AI-assisted work product are verified, not trusted, and the Curated Prompts memorandum supplies the workflow. The citation-checking prompt extracts every case cited in a document and builds a Westlaw citation-field search:

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CI("59 Cal.4th 258")
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The companion statute prompt builds the parallel search for the statutory citations, semicolon-separated for the annotated California database:

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CA VEH § 21453; CA VEH § 21455.5; CA VEH § 21455.7; CA VEH § 40518;  
CA VEH § 40520; CA VEH § 40902
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The searches were run in a Westlaw session, the result counts were checked against the number of authorities cited, and the opinions and code sections were downloaded as single-column PDFs. The downloaded text then served two purposes: it authenticated what the memoranda cited — each citation matched the official reporter citation, and each pinpoint supported its proposition — and it became part of the closed corpus the drafts were checked against. This is the step that replaces “the AI said so” with “the authority is in the file.”

V. DEMONSTRATION FOUR: GROUNDING IN THE CHARGING DOCUMENTS

The final demonstration is the one that won the case, and it is the discipline most directly transferable to daily practice: grounding the AI in the actual documents from the court. The file — the final notice, the filed request for trial by written declaration, the court-prepared TR-205 form — was loaded as the only source, and the model was asked what the file established and what it did not, against the statutory checklist from Demonstration One.

That review surfaced deficiencies a manual read had not flagged. No document in the file stated the date of the underlying violation, which made compliance with the 15-day mailing requirement unverifiable. The final notice provided only the court’s contact information, not the issuing agency’s, despite section 40518, subdivision (b)(2), requiring the agency’s contact information and a description of how to view and discuss the evidence with the agency. Three different versions of the defendant’s name appeared across the charging documents, the pleading, and the court-prepared trial form. Each finding was tied to a specific document and a specific statutory requirement — quoted language, with location — which is what makes this kind of AI review verifiable rather than speculative. The findings went into the Declaration of Facts, along with a Public Records Act request and a section 21455.5, subdivision (g), evidence inspection demand generated the same way.

VI. THE DIVISION OF LABOR AND THE OUTCOME

It is worth being precise about what the tools did and what the attorney did, because that division is the substance of the ethical obligations this program covers. The AI read the statutes and local rules from the repositories, drafted both memoranda, built the Westlaw searches, reviewed the file against the statutory checklist, drafted every document, and filled the Judicial Council TR-205 form programmatically. The attorney supplied the facts, ran the Westlaw session and verified every authority against the downloaded text, made the strategic calls — contest rather than pay, written declaration rather than appearance, which deficiencies to lead with — and signed the filings. Nothing went out unverified. The result was a defense of a \$301 citation that would have been economically irrational at ordinary drafting speed, produced in a few hours — and it worked. On June 30, 2026, the court found the defendant not guilty on the written declarations and ordered the bail refunded in full.

VII. THE GOVERNMENT-SIDE FLIP

For this audience, the case study has a second reading. Every defense ground in Demonstration One is a compliance obligation of the public agency operating the system: the signage, the warning period, the safety finding, the screening guidelines, the calibration records, the officer review, the hearing, the vendor contract terms. An office advising an agency that operates an automated enforcement program — or any program built on a statute with enumerated operational requirements — can run exactly the workflow described here from the other direction: ground the AI in the governing statute from the codes repository, have it build the compliance checklist with quoted language and locations, and audit the client agency's program against it before a defendant does. The same discipline that makes AI safe for a defendant's research makes it useful for preventive compliance review.